Wild Embers: Poems of Rebellion, Fire and Beauty

By Nikita Gill

(Pg 59) Fairytales exist.

They always have.

We just have to rewrite them

over and over again

till they fit.

INTRODUCTION

*If words are magic, then poetry is the ultimate magic. Nikita Gill said: "The greatest wish I have ever had is to create with words what wizards cannot and what magic never has. The most elegant bond I can ever pray for is aiding in the recovery of someone who is made of wreckage and facilitating their becoming their own hero in their story."**

In these poems from her book Wild Embers, Nikita Gill re-imagines heroines of well-known fairy tales as powerful heroes of their own stories. And in doing so, she inspires us to rewrite our own narratives and encourage the next generation of women to do the same.

Poems from Wild Embers by Nikita Gill

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Heros (Pg 70)

We feed ourselves

so many stories

of princes and saviours

coming to protect us

from our monster,

from our demons,

that we forget there

is nothing more beautiful,

more fulfilling,

than becoming our own heroes,

than saving ourselves.

Sleeping Beauty (Pg 60)

The version of Sleeping Beauty I tell my daughter will be a fairytale about consent before it is a fairytale about true love. In it, I will pause and ask her, 'Do you think it was right for the Prince to kiss a girl who was unconscious, just because he thinks she is pretty?' And I expect her to say, 'No. No, it is not!'

In my story, Aurora will not marry the Prince. In my story, Aurora will stand tall, say 'no' to a marriage with a man she barely knows and rule her father's kingdom all on her own.

I will use this story to help her understand, no boy has the right to touch her without her consent just because he thinks she is pretty.

I will teach her to say the word 'No,' before she learns 'Yes.' I will teach her that others may think she is being difficult, but no one's opinion matters as much as her own.

And most important of all, I will teach her never to feel guilty or wear her body as though it is a gift to anyone except herself.

Belle (Pg 61)

Belle is fierce in the way lionesses are when they hunt. She fears nothing and takes on monsters with ease when it comes to protecting the

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people she loves. She looks at someone and sees their inner beauty before she allows herself to fall in anything close to love. She sacrifices her freedom, her most treasured possession, for her father. She stands out from the crowd and reads in a time when education for women was unheard of. Her kindness and willingness to give to others is where her true beauty lies.

And yet, in the fairytales we tell our children, we first introduce her as beautiful rather than fierce, kind, independent, intelligent, giving, full of light and powerful. Even her name is a testament to outward beauty.

Her name should never have been Belle. Her name should have been Feroce. Her name should have been Liberte.

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Snow White (Pg 64-65)

The thing with Snow White is that she isn't so Snow White when the hunter tries to kill her. She grew up in a home with a stepmother who was cruel, which led her to believe that she needed to learn self defense before she sang to the birds or baked apple pie. Because little girls who grow up with the constant threat of a parent who does not love them in their lives learn to listen for footsteps, watch body language and understand it is they who are responsible for their own little lives.

Imagine, young Snow White in the soldier's training area, wielding a sword, being taught by her father's knights how to overcome any enemy. By the time she is grown, the girl knows her way around a bow and arrow better than she knows around a kitchen and the hunter had no idea what hit him when the princess he thought an easy mark had him on his back, his own sword turned on him in a second.

The seven dwarves didn't give her refuge so she could cook and clean and do their laundry, they gave her refuge because they knew she was the rightful and just hear to the throne, also, they were just decent human beings. And Snow White never bit that apple, because she knew better than to be pressured by strange old ladies she had only just met.

She spent her years in the forest making up an army to reclaim her throne.

Don't ever let them tell you that girls are made for glass boxes and princes and apples pies when girls are made for swords and shields and anything else they damn well want to be.

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Cinderella (Pg 66)

There is only so much a good person can be verbally insulted and abused before they unleash their inner, sleeping dragon. And this is why Cinderella, locked in her attic, doomed to a life of cleaning, decided enough was enough and decided to take some action.

Cinderella's fairy Godmother wasn't a fairy Godmother at all. She was the best damned lawyer in town, and she took Cinderella's stepsisters and stepmother to the cleaners before they were unceremoniously thrown out of a house that wasn't theirs. At the end of the day, that house was her father's last possession and as its mistress, Cinderella could return it to its former glory and bring back its sunny disposition. She didn't need to worry about balls and glass slippers because she took over her father's business of trading beautifully woven fabric from lands far and wide.

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When the Prince did come to her door, he hand delivered her invitation, and Cinderella, who had to leave for a business trip that very evening, told him she had no inclination. She needed no husband at the tender age of nineteen. And she didn't want to become a princess and abandon what she had built, as a royal she would have no time. Because girls who were building empires for themselves did not need kingdoms to shine.

Girls of the Wild (Pg 72)

They won't tell you fairytales
of how girls can be dangerous and still win.
They will only tell you stories
where girls are sweet and kind
and reject all sin.
I guess to them it's a terrifying thought,
a Red Riding Hood
who knew exactly
what she was doing
when she invited the wild in.

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Little Red Riding Hood (Pg 67)

Girls who survive trauma wear a certain vulnerability around them, and some men are wolves, they look for those girls, their eyes hungry for prey, their tongues filled with lies to pull girls like this back into the void they have just escaped from.

Little Red Riding Hood was a survivor too, and once, when a man had taken a step too far, she had told the story of what she did to the last thing that tried to devour her.

'I let the wild seep in,' she said, her voice perilously low, 'I let him think he was going to win, but little did he know, I bare teeth too, sharper than his and a heart that has survived terrible pain young. When he tried to devour me, I took the axe from the basket and hacked until he was done.'

If you want to know the secret, if you want to know the truth, there is nothing more dangerous

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than a girl who is aware of the flames inside her, and all the damage she can do.

Yes. Girls who survive trauma do wear a certain vulnerability around them, but this kind of vulnerability is from where their greatest strength stems.

Bedtime Stories (Pg 147)

When your daughter asks you to tell her bedtime stories, the kind that you grew up with, I hope you tell her better versions.

I hope you tell her bedtime stories where the princess isn't a princess but a knight and she's going to war with dragons all by herself. I hope you tell her stories where the princess rescues her father's kingdom from impending doom. I hope you tell her stores where girls save themselves from anything. And no towers and monsters and dragons and kings can ever stop them from doing what they want to do.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Nikita Gill
ISBN: 978-1549113314
Publisher: Hachette Books
Date (Month/Year): Nov 2017

AWARD HISTORY

MO State Qualifier

****Introductory Quote from Wild Embers, Pg 26***

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